

STAGE SIX • COMMUNICATION: SPEAKING, READING & WRITING

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 70 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Six • Communication: Speaking, Reading & Writing

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage Six, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook (Parts 1 and 2) — it does not replace them.

Stage Six is the largest single stage in the program: seventy FIRSTS across six sections, organized here into six sessions matching the Manual's structure: Written Communication, Verbal & Presentation Skills, Listening/Reading & Comprehension, Interpersonal & Networking Communication, Feedback/Reflection & Self-Assessment, and Communication Systems & Tools.

Given the sheer volume, entries in this guide are intentionally more concise than in smaller stages: a one-sentence objective, two key talking points, and the single most common misconception, rather than an extended discussion per FIRST. This keeps the guide genuinely usable at this scale rather than becoming a document no one actually reads in full before facilitating.

Chapter numbers in this stage are non-sequential within each section (for example, Section 1 runs I1, I2, I8, I9...) — this matches the Manual and Templates exactly, and is intentional, not an error.

SESSION 1

Written Communication

Covers *FIRSTS I1-I65 (non-sequential) (17 items)*

FIRST I1

Professional Email Sent

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants send a real, concise professional email with a clear purpose stated in the first two sentences.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Email is the default professional channel — a poorly structured one can undercut a strong candidate before any other impression forms.
- Clear subject line + purpose up front + one specific ask + professional close is the whole formula.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Burying the actual request several paragraphs in.
- Using an overly casual tone with someone you don't know well.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I2

Meeting Agenda Prepared

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a realistic agenda with time estimates for a real upcoming meeting.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Meetings without agendas drift, run long, and leave people unsure what was decided.
- An agenda only works if it's actually followed during the meeting, not just written and ignored.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Packing in too many topics without realistic time estimates.
- Writing an agenda but never actually referencing it live.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I8

Written Report Drafted

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants outline before drafting a real report, avoiding a stream-of-consciousness first pass.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Reports are a core deliverable in nearly every field; disorganization undermines even strong analysis.
- Outlining first prevents the report from reading like unstructured thinking.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Starting full sentences before outlining.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I9

Report Edited for Clarity

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants edit a report in a separate sitting from when it was drafted.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Drafting and editing are different cognitive tasks — doing both at once means missing issues you're too close to see.
- A genuine gap in time (even overnight) meaningfully improves editing quality.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Editing immediately after drafting in the same sitting.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I10

Technical Document Created

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants document a real technical process assuming zero prior context from the reader.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Undocumented technical work is invisible to anyone not directly involved.
- “Obvious to me” is exactly the assumption that breaks documentation for someone else.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming steps are obvious because they're obvious to the writer.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I15

Persuasive Email Sent

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a real persuasive email framed around the recipient's actual interests, not just their own need.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuine persuasion, not just a polite ask, meaningfully affects response rates.
- Framing around what the recipient cares about beats framing around what you need.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Focusing only on your own need rather than the recipient's actual interest.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I18

Business Proposal Drafted

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a structured proposal with a clear ask and addressed objections.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A structured proposal is far more likely to get approved than an idea pitched verbally or in a scattered message.
- Writing forces you to think through the case before asking for buy-in.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- All enthusiasm, no structure, missing a clear ask.
 - Failing to address obvious costs or objections.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min

FIRST I19

Meeting Minutes Documented

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write real meeting minutes as a useful summary, not a verbatim transcript.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without written minutes, decisions and commitments fade or get remembered differently by different people.
- Minutes should be a summary of decisions and owners, not a transcript.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Trying to write down everything verbatim.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I24

Summary Email Sent After Meeting

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants send a quick summary email after a real meeting to catch misunderstandings early.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A summary gives everyone a chance to correct a misunderstanding before it causes a problem later.
- Internal miscommunication is just as costly as external — don't skip this for “informal” meetings.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping this for internal meetings because it feels unnecessary.

SUGGESTED TIME: 10 min

FIRST I33

Follow-Up Email After Networking

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants send a specific, genuine follow-up email referencing something real from a networking conversation.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most networking connections fade without a follow-up.
- A specific reference (not a generic template) is what actually turns a conversation into a relationship.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Sending a generic message with no specific reference.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I38

Written Technical Summary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a summary of technical work for a non-technical audience without losing accuracy.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Explaining technical work simply lets it be understood and valued by decision-makers outside your function.
- Simplification and inaccuracy are not the same thing — the goal is clarity, not loss of substance.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Removing so much detail the summary becomes inaccurate rather than simplified.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I39

Email Etiquette Audit

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants review a real batch of their own sent emails to identify genuine patterns.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Patterns are invisible email by email but obvious in aggregate.
- A couple of emails isn't enough sample size — review a genuine batch.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Reviewing only a couple of emails, missing the real pattern.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I44

Written Proposal Feedback

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants request real feedback on a proposal early enough to actually act on it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A proposal never reviewed by anyone but its author has blind spots the author can't see.
- Feedback requested too late to act on defeats the purpose of asking at all.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Asking for feedback too late to act on it.
- Dismissing uncomfortable feedback rather than genuinely considering it.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I46

Email to Recruiter

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants draft a specific, well-structured email to a real recruiter with a clear ask.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Recruiters receive high volumes of generic outreach; specificity is what stands out.
- A vague ask makes it easy for a busy recruiter to skip past.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Being too vague about what you're actually asking for.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I50

Collaborative Document Editing

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice leaving explained comments rather than silent edits on someone else's writing.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most real professional writing happens collaboratively.
- Silent edits without explanation feel presumptuous and create confusion about what changed and why.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Making silent edits without explanation.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST 162

Written Executive Summary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write an executive summary tight enough for a reader with limited time.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Busy decision-makers often only read the summary, not the full report.
- A weak summary can mean strong underlying work never gets real attention.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Trying to include too much detail, defeating the summary's purpose.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 165

Email Draft Templates Library

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a small library of adaptable templates for their most frequent email types.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Writing every email from scratch is slow and risks forgetting a key element under time pressure.
- A template's value depends entirely on genuine personalization when used.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Sending a template without personalizing the placeholders.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

SESSION 2

Verbal & Presentation Skills

Covers *FIRSTS I3-I66 (non-sequential) (15 items)*

FIRST I3

Presentation Script Written

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants loosely script a real presentation's structure without writing every word verbatim.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Unscripted presentations tend to ramble or lose the thread.
- Full word-for-word scripting produces stiff, read-aloud delivery instead of natural speech.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Scripting every single word for a live presentation.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I4

Presentation Delivered

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliver a real presentation live, not just rehearse it silently.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Writing a script and delivering it live are different skills.
- Practicing live delivery specifically, out loud, under mild pressure, is what actually builds confidence.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only practicing silently in your head.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I5

Public Speaking Recording

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants record a real speaking moment, watch it back, and note one specific fixable habit.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most people underestimate their own filler words and pacing issues until they see themselves on video.
- The playback review is where the actual learning happens — don't skip it.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping the playback review entirely.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I11

Elevator Pitch Practiced

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice their pitch out loud, not just review it on paper.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A pitch only ever written, never spoken, tends to sound stiff the first time it's needed under real pressure.
- Silent rehearsal doesn't reveal how the pitch actually sounds aloud.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only rehearsing silently in your head.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I20

Storytelling Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants reframe a piece of real information as a narrative rather than a list of facts.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Stories are dramatically more memorable than lists of facts.
- Narrative structure should clarify substance, not obscure it with unnecessary flourish.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Adding flourishes that obscure the actual substance.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I21

Voice Recording Review

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants review a voice recording across specific dimensions (tone, pace, clarity) rather than a general impression.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Breaking “how did I sound” into specific dimensions makes feedback actionable.
- A vague “good or bad” impression misses specific, fixable patterns.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Reviewing for a general impression only.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST 122

Presentation Slide Deck Created

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build slides that reinforce, rather than compete with, the spoken message.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Text-heavy slides compete with the speaker for audience attention.
- Well-designed slides give the audience a clear anchor, not a script to read along with.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating slides as a teleprompter with full sentences.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 123

Debate Participation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants argue a real position supported by evidence, anticipating counterarguments.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Debate forces anticipation of counterarguments and evidence-backed claims.
- This discipline strengthens persuasive writing and speaking well beyond the debate format itself.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Relying on assertion and rhetorical force instead of actual evidence.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min

FIRST 128

Group Presentation Coordinated

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rehearse a full group presentation together, not just individual sections separately.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Group presentations often fail because pieces don't connect, not because any one section is weak.
- Coordination is a distinct skill from individual presenting.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only rehearsing individual sections separately, never the full group flow.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 129

Impromptu Speaking Drill

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice speaking with no preparation time on a surprise prompt.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Not every speaking moment allows for preparation — interviews, meetings, and on-the-spot updates all require this.
- The discomfort of practicing this is exactly the discomfort real impromptu moments require handling.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding the exercise because it feels awkward.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I31

Persuasive Presentation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants structure a presentation around a clear ask stated early, not built up to at the end.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Persuasive presentations need a clear ask, addressed objections, and a call to action — not just information transfer.
- State the ask early and support it, rather than building up to a conclusion informational-style.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Structuring a persuasive presentation like an informational one.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I51

Presentation to Non-Expert Audience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliver a presentation calibrated to an audience without their specific background knowledge.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Presenting clearly to non-experts widens who can understand and value your work.
- Assuming shared background knowledge is a common blind spot within any specialized field.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming the audience shares more background knowledge than they actually do.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I57

Elevator Pitch Refinement

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants revise their pitch based on how it actually lands when spoken aloud to a real listener.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A pitch drafted once and never revisited drifts out of date or never improves past its roughest version.
- Revise based on real spoken delivery, not how it reads silently on paper.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Revising based on how the pitch reads on paper rather than how it lands spoken aloud.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

FIRST 163

Peer Learning Circle Presentation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants teach a piece of material informally to peers, without over-scripting the format.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Teaching material to peers deepens your own understanding while building low-pressure presentation reps.
- This should stay a discussion-friendly format, not a fully scripted formal talk.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Over-preparing a fully scripted talk for what should be an informal format.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

FIRST 166

Read-Aloud Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants read a passage aloud at a deliberately measured pace.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Regular read-aloud practice builds vocal clarity and pacing control in a low-pressure setting.
- These muscles transfer directly to presentations and interviews.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Rushing through the exercise the same way you rush when nervous.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: *10 min*

SESSION 3

Listening, Reading & Comprehension

Covers *FIRSTS I6–I55 (non-sequential) (8 items)*

FIRST I6

Active Listening Drill

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice paraphrasing a real conversation partner before responding with their own point.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most people listen to respond, not to understand — this shows in disjointed conversations.
- Genuine listening builds trust faster than almost any other communication skill.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Summarizing so mechanically it feels performative.
 - Only practicing this in obviously high-stakes conversations rather than as a real habit.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I14

Reading Summary Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants summarize a piece of reading from memory, without looking at the original.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Extracting the core insight quickly is essential for staying current without drowning in information.
- Summarizing while still looking at the text tests copying, not actual comprehension.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing the summary while still looking at the original.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I26

Podcast or Video Commentary

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants actively process and record their own take on a podcast or video, not just consume it passively.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Passive listening or watching often leads to poor retention.

- Active summarizing and analysis converts consumption into genuine, usable learning.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Consuming content passively without ever processing or recording a take.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST 127

Reading Comprehension Challenge

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants read material genuinely beyond their current comfort level and work through it rather than giving up.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Comprehension improves fastest when challenged just beyond current comfort, not on material that's already easy.
- A second, more careful pass is often necessary for genuinely difficult material.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Giving up after one pass through difficult material.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 135

Reading List for Career Growth

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a targeted reading list based on real recommendations from people in their target field.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Deliberate, targeted reading builds field-specific fluency faster than passive, undirected consumption.
- Generic “best books” roundups aren't a substitute for real field-specific recommendations.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Building a generic list from online roundups instead of real recommendations.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST 147

Reflective Reading Journal

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a journal entry with genuine personal reaction, not just a summary of the reading.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a running record, insights from reading fade quickly.

- A journal's real value is the reflection, not a restated summary of content.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing pure summaries without personal reaction or genuine questions.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST 149

Reading Speed & Comprehension Drill

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice distinguishing when skimming is appropriate versus when deep reading is required.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Professional roles often require processing large volumes of material quickly.
- Skimming and deep reading are distinct, learnable skills — knowing when to use each matters as much as either skill alone.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Applying skimming to material that actually requires careful, deep reading.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST 155

Listening and Summarization Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants summarize what they heard immediately after listening, not after a delay.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Summarizing shortly after listening reveals genuine retention versus what only felt understood in the moment.
- Waiting too long means reconstructing rather than recalling.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Waiting too long after consuming content before summarizing.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

SESSION 4

Interpersonal & Networking Communication

Covers *FIRSTS I12-I69 (non-sequential) (13 items)*

FIRST I12

Networking Conversation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants sustain a genuine networking conversation past the first minute, not just deliver an opening line.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Many people can introduce themselves but struggle to sustain a conversation.
- Genuine networking value comes from the sustained exchange, not just the opener.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Turning the conversation into a monologue about yourself.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I13

Mock Interview

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice interview delivery specifically — clarity and confidence, not just content.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Interview content (what you say) and delivery (how you say it) are distinct skills.
- This FIRST focuses specifically on the communication dimension, not answer content.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Focusing mock interview practice only on content while ignoring delivery.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 25 min

FIRST I16

Discussion Facilitation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice facilitating a real discussion, actively drawing out quieter voices.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Facilitation is distinct from simply participating.
- A good facilitator actively creates space for quieter voices, not just manages louder ones.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting the loudest voices dominate without actively creating space for others.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I17

Cross-Cultural Communication Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify and adjust for a genuine cross-cultural communication difference.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Increasingly diverse, global workplaces require genuine cross-cultural skill.
- Your own default communication style doesn't automatically translate universally.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming your own default communication style translates universally without checking.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I32

Professional Networking Introduction

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants craft an introduction with one genuinely memorable, relevant detail.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- In a room of similar introductions, a genuinely memorable one is what gets followed up on.
- The memorable detail needs to connect to real professional value, not just be a gimmick.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Making the memorable detail irrelevant or gimmicky rather than genuinely connected.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I37

Online Discussion Participation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants contribute a genuinely substantive comment to a real online professional discussion.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Online participation is often the lowest-pressure way to build visibility before higher-stakes engagement.
- Generic agreement adds nothing — substance is what actually builds visibility.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Contributing generic agreement or surface-level comments.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I41

Professional Chat with Senior

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants have a real conversation with a senior professional, calibrating comfort in that specific dynamic.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Conversations with senior professionals carry a different dynamic than peer conversations.
- This specific practice builds comfort that peer interaction alone doesn't provide.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Staying too silent out of intimidation.
 - Over-talking to compensate for nervousness.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I42

Conflict Resolution Conversation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants address a real disagreement directly and professionally rather than avoiding it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Avoided conflict doesn't disappear — it tends to resurface worse later.
- This is a distinct, learnable skill most people never practice deliberately.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding the conversation entirely.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I45

Meeting Facilitation in Class/Group

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants facilitate a real class or group meeting, redirecting and summarizing along the way.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Academic and club settings are lower-stakes places to practice facilitation before a workplace meeting.
- Redirecting wandering discussion and summarizing decisions are the core facilitator moves.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting the discussion wander without redirecting or summarizing.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I48

Online Course Discussion Participation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants genuinely engage with an online learning community, not just complete course content solo.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Online learning communities are increasingly common professional development spaces.
- Genuine participation, not just completion, is what builds real connections and deeper learning.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating online courses as purely solitary, completion-focused exercises.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST 153

Professional Social Media Commenting

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants leave a genuinely specific, thoughtful comment on real professional content.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Thoughtful commenting builds visibility and relationships with less effort than original content creation.
- Generic comments read as low-effort and rarely generate real engagement.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Leaving generic comments that could apply to any post.

SUGGESTED TIME: 10 min

FIRST 164

Scenario-Based Communication Drill

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants role-play a genuinely difficult communication scenario rather than only thinking about it hypothetically.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Low-stakes role-play builds real readiness that pure hypothetical thinking doesn't provide.
- The scenarios that feel too uncomfortable to role-play are often exactly the ones that benefit most from practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping preparation for scenarios that feel too uncomfortable to role-play.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 169

Public Forum Participation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants prepare and deliver a concise comment or question in a real public forum setting.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Public forums require comfort speaking to a broader, often unfamiliar audience than a classroom or team.
- Respecting shared time with a concise comment matters as much as the content itself.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Preparing a comment so long or rambling it doesn't respect the forum's shared time.

SUGGESTED TIME: *15 min*

SESSION 5

Feedback, Reflection & Self-Assessment

Covers *FIRSTS I7-I70 (non-sequential) (9 items)*

FIRST I7

Feedback Response

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice receiving real critical feedback without becoming defensive.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- How you respond to feedback in the moment shapes whether people feel comfortable giving you honest input again.
- Defensiveness or immediate explanation discourages future honest feedback.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Becoming defensive or immediately explaining your reasoning.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I25

Professional Feedback Given

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants give a peer genuine, specific feedback despite the discomfort.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Giving feedback well is just as important a skill as receiving it.
- Avoiding it out of discomfort deprives your peer of genuinely useful input.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding giving feedback entirely out of discomfort.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I30

Written Reflection on Learning

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a genuine personal reflection on a real learning experience, not a content summary.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without deliberate reflection, specific lessons fade quickly into vague impressions.
- A summary of content is not the same as genuine personal reflection on application.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing only a summary of course content rather than genuine personal reflection.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I36

Communication Self-Assessment

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants rate their own communication skills using specific, real evidence, not vague impressions.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without an honest baseline, improvement efforts tend to be scattered rather than targeted.
- Specific real instances make the self-assessment genuinely useful.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Rating yourself based on vague impressions rather than specific evidence.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I40

Reflection on Public Speaking Anxiety

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify their own specific anxiety triggers rather than treating anxiety as one undifferentiated feeling.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Public speaking anxiety is extremely common but rarely examined specifically.
- Specific triggers may call for different strategies — undifferentiated anxiety is hard to actually address.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Treating anxiety as one undifferentiated feeling rather than examining specific triggers.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I54

Peer Review Feedback

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants give written peer feedback tied to specific, actionable examples in real work.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Written peer review requires more precision than casual verbal feedback.
- The discipline of doing it well sharpens your own critical eye, not just the peer's work.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Giving vague, general feedback not tied to specific examples.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 160

Reflective Speaking Log

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants maintain a speaking log including unremarkable days, not just notable ones.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Speaking improvement often happens gradually enough to be invisible day to day.
- A running log makes real progress visible in a way daily experience alone doesn't.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping entries on days when practice felt unremarkable.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 10 min

FIRST 167

Communication Reflection with Mentor

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants genuinely invite a mentor's disagreement or additions, not just share a self-assessment.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Self-assessment alone has blind spots a mentor who's observed you in real situations can see.
- Only sharing your own view without inviting real pushback limits the value of outside perspective.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only sharing your self-assessment without genuinely asking for disagreement or additions.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST 170

Reflection on Persuasion Techniques

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants analyze one specific, real example of persuasion that actually worked on them.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Analyzing a real example makes persuasion's mechanics visible in a way abstract theory doesn't.
- Ground the analysis in something concrete, not a generic discussion of persuasion principles.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Analyzing persuasion only in the abstract, without a specific real example.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

SESSION 6

Communication Systems & Tools

Covers *FIRSTS I34–I68 (non-sequential) (8 items)*

FIRST I34

Documented Communication Goals

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write specific, measurable communication goals rather than vague intentions.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Vague intentions to “communicate better” rarely lead to real improvement.
- Specific, documented goals give you something concrete to work toward and measure.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Setting vague, unmeasurable goals.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I43

Visual Communication Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants translate a data- or process-heavy idea into a clear visual.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Some ideas communicate far more clearly through a well-designed visual than through text.
- Over-designing obscures rather than clarifies — simplicity usually wins.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Over-designing a visual with unnecessary complexity or decoration.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I52

Active Note-Taking System

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants build a note-taking system that actively selects and structures key points, not transcribes everything.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Trying to write down everything produces notes that are hard to review and reflect passive engagement.
- Active selection and structure is what makes notes genuinely useful later.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Trying to write down everything verbatim.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I56

Communication Flow Mapping

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants map who needs to receive what information, and when, for a real project.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a deliberate flow, updates reach some stakeholders and miss others entirely.
- This matters more as project complexity grows — don't assume information naturally reaches everyone.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming information will naturally reach everyone who needs it.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I58

Storyboard Creation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants storyboard a piece of content's visual and narrative sequence before producing it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Planning sequence before producing content saves significant rework.
- Skipping this step often means discovering structural problems after significant work is already done.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping storyboarding and jumping straight into production.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I59

Communication Metrics Tracking

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants track a small, sustainable set of real communication metrics over time.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Subjective impressions of your own improvement are unreliable.
- Tracked metrics give objective evidence of what's actually working — but too many at once becomes a burden.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Tracking too many metrics at once.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST I61

Interview Question Bank Created

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants prepare and refine answers to likely interview questions in advance, without over-memorizing.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Having answers already thought through means not starting from scratch under real interview pressure.
- Rigid memorization sounds robotic rather than genuinely conversational when delivered live.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Memorizing answers so rigidly they sound robotic.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST I68

Communication Challenge Goal

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants set one specific, assessable weekly communication stretch goal.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A single weekly stretch goal is more sustainable and trackable than a vague ongoing intention.
- A goal too vague to assess at week's end undermines the accountability the exercise is meant to provide.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Choosing a goal too vague to actually assess at week's end.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 10 min